



Presets in Lightroom Classic

Using presets. Editing your own look. Saving it for every future project.

1. What is a Preset?

2. Using Presets

3. Edit Your Look

4. Save Your Preset

5. Apply & Manage

What is a Develop Preset?

A Develop Preset is a saved group of edit settings that you can apply to any photo in one click. It stores your adjustments from the Develop module and applies them instantly to any image.



Save Time

Instead of making the same adjustments on 200 photos one at a time, apply your preset to all of them in seconds. This is the core of a professional editing workflow.



Build Your Style

Your preset becomes your signature look. Consistent tone, color, and feel across every image in a portfolio makes your work recognizable as yours.



Create a Starting Point

A preset is not a one-click fix. It gets you 80% of the way there quickly, then you fine-tune each image individually from that starting point.

Finding the Presets Panel

All presets live in the Develop module. You need to be there before you can use or create any preset.

1 Go to the Develop module

Click Develop at the top right of Lightroom Classic. You must be in Develop, not Library, to access presets.

2 Open one of your images

Click on any image in your filmstrip at the bottom of the screen. The image will open in the editing view.

3 Look at the left panel

On the LEFT side of the Develop module you will see the Presets panel. Click the arrow next to it if it is collapsed.

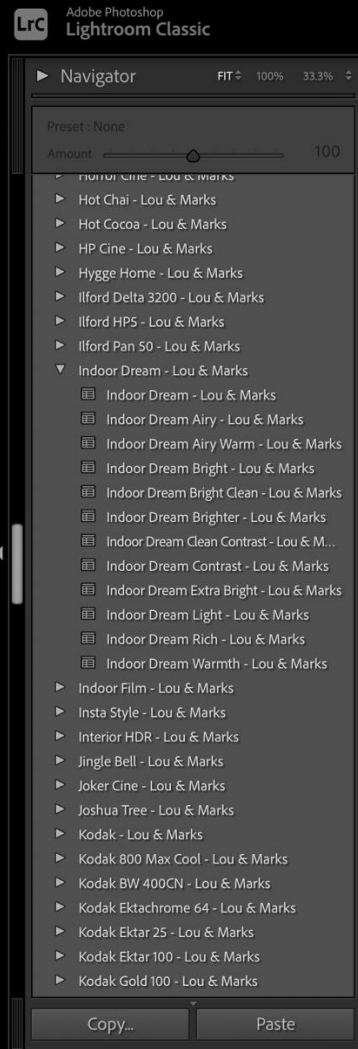
4 Expand the preset groups

You will see folders like Lightroom Classic Presets, Color Presets, and User Presets. Click the arrow next to any group to see the presets inside.

5 Hover to preview

Move your mouse over any preset name WITHOUT clicking. The preview image at the top left will update to show what that preset looks like on your photo.

Pro Tip: Use the Search bar at the top of the Presets panel to find a preset by name. Added in Lightroom Classic version 13.



Applying and Adjusting a Preset

1

Click a preset to apply it

Single click any preset name to apply it to your current image. The sliders on the right panel will update instantly to show the new values.

2

Check the Amount slider

At the top of the Presets panel, look for an Amount slider. Drag it left to reduce the intensity of the preset, or right to increase it. Not all presets support this.

3

Fine-tune in the right panel

A preset is a starting point. After applying it, use the Basic panel on the right to adjust Exposure, White Balance, and any other settings specific to your image.

4

Undo if needed

Press Ctrl + Z (Windows) or Command + Z (Mac) to undo the preset. Or press the Reset button at the bottom right of the Develop module to clear all edits.

Keyboard shortcut to create a new preset: Ctrl + Shift + N (Win) or Cmd + Shift + N (Mac)

You can apply presets in three places:



Develop module

Main editing view. Most control.



Library Quick Develop

Right panel in Library. Fast batch apply.



During Import

Apply During Import panel. Applies to all incoming photos.

Step 1: Edit a Photo to Your Desired Look

You cannot save a preset from nothing. You have to edit a photo first, then save those edits as a preset.

Best Practices



Use a RAW file. RAW files give presets much more flexibility than JPEGs.



Start with a well-exposed image in natural light. Extreme exposures make presets look inconsistent on other photos.



Focus on the adjustments you use on every shoot: Tone Curve, Color Grading, HSL, Grain, Sharpening.



Avoid including Exposure and White Balance in most presets. These are image-specific and will look wrong on other photos.



Panels to Explore

Basic Panel

Tone, Contrast, Texture, Clarity, Vibrance, Saturation

Tone Curve

Fine control over highlights, midtones, and shadows — great for a film look

HSL / Color

Adjust the hue, saturation, and luminance of individual colors

Color Grading

Add color casts to shadows, midtones, and highlights separately

Detail

Sharpening and Noise Reduction — essential for all presets

Effects

Grain and Vignette — signature style elements

Step 2: Open the New Develop Preset Dialog

Once your image looks exactly how you want, you are ready to save those settings as a preset.

Three ways to open the New Develop Preset dialog:

A

Click the + in the Presets panel

In the left panel of the Develop module, look at the top-right of the Presets panel header. Click the small + icon. Choose Create Preset from the dropdown.

B

Use the top menu

Go to Develop in the menu bar at the very top of Lightroom. Choose New Preset from the dropdown menu.

C

Use the keyboard shortcut

Press Ctrl + Shift + N on Windows or Command + Shift + N on Mac. This is the fastest method and the one professionals use.

The dialog will show:

Preset Name A text field to name your preset

Group A dropdown to choose which folder it saves to

Checkboxes A list of every possible setting you can include

Check All / None Buttons to select or deselect all settings at once

Create button Saves the preset when you are done

Step 3: Name, Group, and Choose Settings

This is the most important step. Take your time here.

01 Preset Name

Choose a clear, descriptive name. You will have many presets eventually.

"Warm Film Portrait" is better than "My Edit 1"

02 Group (Folder)

Save your own presets to User Presets by default, or create a new folder. Example folders: My Portrait Presets, My Black and White Presets.

03 Choose Which Settings to Include



Tone Curve

Core of your look — always include



HSL / Color

Your color style — include if adjusted



Color Grading

Shadow and highlight color — include



Detail (Sharpening + NR)

Include if consistent across your work



Effects (Grain, Vignette)

Signature style — include



White Balance

Skip — every photo has different light



Exposure

Skip — every photo is different



Lens Corrections

Skip — depends on the lens used

Step 4: Click Create and Confirm It Saved

1

Click the Create button

At the bottom right of the New Develop Preset dialog, click Create. The dialog will close automatically.

2

Find it in the Presets panel

Look in the Presets panel on the left. Find the group you saved it to. Your new preset will be listed there alphabetically.

3

Test it on a different photo

Click a completely different photo in the filmstrip. Apply your new preset and see how it looks. Adjust anything that looks off.

4

Update the preset if needed

Make changes to the image in the Develop module. Then right-click your preset in the Presets panel and choose Update with Current Settings to overwrite it.

Good to know:



XMP file format

Presets are saved as .xmp files on your computer. This makes them compatible with Lightroom Classic, Lightroom, and Camera Raw.



Share your preset

Right-click your preset and choose Export. This creates an .xmp file you can send to anyone or back up to OneDrive.



Import a preset

Click the + in the Presets panel, choose Import Presets, and select an .xmp or .zip file to add it to your library.

Apply Your Preset to a Full Shoot

This is where your preset saves you real time. Apply it to every photo from a shoot at once.

1

Go to the Library module

Press G to enter Grid view. You will see all your photos as thumbnails.

2

Select all the photos from your shoot

Click the first photo, then hold Shift and click the last one to select the entire range. Or press Ctrl + A to select all.

3

Switch to the Develop module

Press D. The first selected photo will open in Develop. All others are still selected in the filmstrip.

4

Apply your preset

Click your preset in the Presets panel. It applies to the current image. Then click Sync at the bottom right to push the settings to all selected photos.

5

Fine-tune individual images

Click through each image in the filmstrip. Adjust Exposure and White Balance individually on any photos that still need work.

Keeping Your Preset Library Organized

As you grow as a photographer you will build a library of presets. Good organization saves time.

Create preset folders



Right-click in the Presets panel and choose New Group. Name it by genre or project: Portraits, Landscapes, Black and White, Film Looks.

Rename a preset



Right-click any preset and choose Rename. Change the name any time without affecting the settings saved inside it.

Delete a preset



Right-click and choose Delete. Be careful — there is no undo. Only delete presets you are certain you no longer need.

Update a preset



Edit any photo in the Develop module, then right-click the preset and choose Update with Current Settings. This overwrites the old version.

Hide preset groups you don't use



Click the + in the Presets panel, choose Manage Presets, and uncheck any built-in groups you want to hide. Keeps things clean.

Back up your presets



Export your User Presets folder regularly. Right-click the group and choose Export Group. Save the .zip to your OneDrive Photography folder.

Build and Save Your Own Preset

Follow these steps to complete the assignment. You will submit a screenshot of your preset in the Presets panel.

01

Open one of your best images

Choose a RAW photo from your most recent project. Open it in the Develop module.

02

Edit it to your signature look

Adjust the Tone Curve, Color Grading, HSL, Detail, and Effects panels. Create a look that feels like your style.

03

Open the New Develop Preset dialog

Press Ctrl + Shift + N (Win) or Cmd + Shift + N (Mac).

04

Name it with your name and style

Format: FirstName_StyleName. Example: Chris_WarmFilm or Silva_HighContrast.

05

Save to User Presets or a new folder

Keep your work organized under a folder with your name or your class period.

06

Test it on two different photos

Apply your preset to two other images from different lighting conditions. Note how it performs and what needs adjusting.

Submission: Take a screenshot of your preset in the Presets panel and upload it to Canvas.

The Full Preset Workflow

Follow this sequence every time you create a new preset.

01 Open an image in Develop

RAW preferred. Well exposed. Representative of your typical work.

02 Edit your signature look

Tone Curve, HSL, Color Grading, Detail, Effects. Avoid Exposure and White Balance.

03 Ctrl/Cmd + Shift + N

Open the New Develop Preset dialog.

04 Name it clearly

Use a name you will recognize in six months. Include your name for class presets.

05 Choose your checkboxes carefully

Include your stylistic settings. Exclude Exposure, White Balance, and Lens Corrections.

06 Click Create

Your preset appears in the Presets panel under the group you chose.

07 Test on two other images

Apply to different photos to see how consistent the look is.

08 Export and back up

Right-click > Export. Save your .xmp file to OneDrive so you never lose it.